environmental activist. He could be stubborn, but he wasn't known to be unreasonable. And he wasn't above striking a 'deal' if necessary.

And yet, the nature of the UPA's response suggested that they were handling a national leader of great stature, a fakir-like figure who had intimidated them into submission. I remember meeting the late Vilasrao Deshmukh, the former Maharashtra chief minister, a few months after the noise had died down. Deshmukh was the one finally chosen to broker peace with Hazare. He told me, 'I wish they had entrusted me with the task from day one. I knew Anna from my Maharashtra days, I would have talked him out of the protests. But our Delhi leaders think they know everything!'

Of these Delhi leaders, Pranab Mukherjee and Chidambaram were the seniormost. Both were seasoned, intelligent politicians. If you wanted to understand how the government functioned, a visit to Pranabda's house post-11 p.m. was mandatory. He was an encyclopaedia on the Congress party and the Constitution. If you challenged him, he would immediately give you a historical reference. And yet, as the government's principal troubleshooter, you sensed he was tiring from the workload. 'I am not getting younger,' he would sometimes tell me.

Chidambaram was younger, with a cutting wit and a sharply sardonic tongue, a supremely knowledgeable intellectual powerhouse, but also someone with a trace of arrogance that made him much more difficult to deal with. If you got on his wrong side, there was no escaping his wrath. Once, during a studio discussion, we erred in putting his name in a list of 'tainted' ministers. He refused to speak to me for almost two years. 'Unless I get a public apology, I will not appear on your channel,' he said with his trademark frostiness. I don't think he was ready to forgive and forget even after we apologized on air.

It was no secret that Mukherjee and Chidambaram did not get along with each other. 'Leaked' reports would often surface that hinted at the two ministers sniping at each other. It didn't help the UPA-II government that the prime minister's two most able lieutenants didn't see eye to eye.

For Manmohan Singh, it was palace intrigue he could have done without in a moment of crisis. The Anna movement hit the credibility of his